

UNDERSTANDING THE INFLUENZA (FLU) VACCINE: WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW

WHAT IS THE INFLUENZA VACCINE?

The influenza vaccine, often called the “flu shot,” is a safe, preventive injection that helps your body build protection against the influenza virus. The vaccine does not cause flu illness. Instead, it trains your immune system to recognize and fight off flu viruses more effectively, like in Figure 1.

WHY GET VACCINATED?

Getting the flu vaccine each year provides several benefits:

- **Protection:** Reduces your risk of catching the flu.
- **Severity:** Lessens symptoms and prevents serious complications if you do get sick.
- **Community Safety:** Protects vulnerable groups such as young children, seniors, and people with chronic illnesses.

SAFETY AND SIDE EFFECTS

The flu vaccine is safe. Most side effects are mild and short-lasting, including:

- Soreness at the injection site
- Low-grade fever
- Muscle aches

Severe allergic reactions are extremely rare.

WHO SHOULD GET THE VACCINE?

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) recommends annual vaccination for everyone six months and older, unless advised otherwise by a healthcare professional (Figure 2). This includes:

- Children and teens
- Adults, especially age 65+
- Pregnant individuals
- People with underlying medical conditions

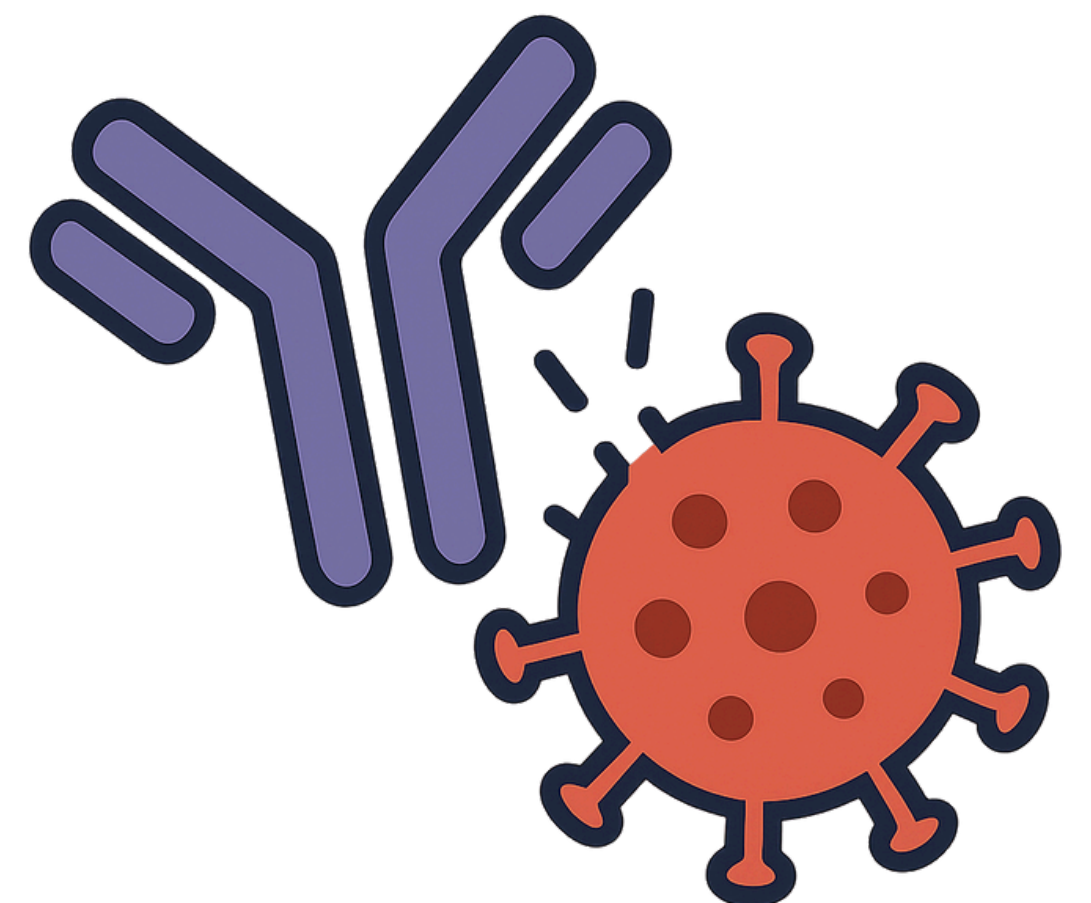


Figure 1: Antibody attacking a flu virus (OpenAI, 2025)



Figure 2: Some of the people who should get a vaccine (istockphoto.com, 2025)

WHEN AND HOW OFTEN?

Flu season typically peaks between October and March. For best protection, get vaccinated early in the fall. Immunity develops about two weeks after vaccination, and yearly vaccination is needed since flu viruses change regularly.